‘not forget to bring his “Phupha”’ – his paternal aunt’s husband, that is, Akbar – when he visited next.

The ground where Man Singh’s untouched meal had been laid out was ‘deemed impure’ as, indeed, was his very presence: the ground was washed in water from the Ganga, and the chiefs ‘bathed and changed their vestments’.

The next time they met, it would not be to exchange barbs, but to war.

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Abul Fazl and the bards of Mewar are not the only ones who speak of Man Singh and Rana Pratap. There is also Man Singh’s own historian, Amrit Rai, author of a ballad-biography called the *Mancharita*. Amrit Rai prefaces his account of the battle of Haldighati with a scene in which Akbar offers paan to a gathering of his generals, asking for volunteers to battle Rana Pratap. It is Man Singh, writes Allison Busch in a lovely essay, who ‘accepts the challenge’. The offering of paan, Busch continues, like the gift of a robe of honour, ‘symbolized the incorporation of the vassal into the body politic’.[34] As Man Singh was shunned by Rana Pratap, who would not eat with him, so he became one with Akbar by eating the proffered paan.

And so, on 18 June 1576, the battle began.

Haldighati is a mountain pass in Udaipur, which had been Mewar’s base ever since the loss of Chittorgarh. When the Mughals fought Mewar at Chittor, it was Mewar’s rana – Udai Singh – who was absent and the Mughal padishah who led his men. This time, the situation was reversed: Rana Pratap leading the charge against a Mughal general, Man Singh.

Man Singh had not brought his phupha along, but he had, perhaps, brought the fury of his humiliation at the taunt. ‘The price of life was low, that of honour high,’ writes Abul Fazl. At dawn, when battle began, ‘Shiva arrives on the scene to augment his skull garland’, in Amrit Rai’s account, ‘and Kali dances in the midst of the carnage’.

It is Badauni, however, who provides an account shorn of metaphor. He was there, having insisted on coming – hoping to escape another translation job, perhaps – declaring his desire to ‘dye these black mustachios and beard in blood through loyalty to your Majesty’s person’.

There was no dearth of gore. And several times, it looked as if the